

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

Module 3 Assignment — Building High-Performing QA Teams

Assignment brief: scenario, deliverables, steps and how your work is assessed.

About this assignment

Northstar has no career framework for QA — no skills matrix and no progression ladder — and the six-person team's skills are uneven: four strong manual and exploratory testers, one automation-leaning engineer, and a recent hire still ramping, with no performance, security or accessibility specialism. Sofia is capable of more but has no defined path, and Dan is isolated on automation. Priya will support development that is tied to Northstar's delivery needs.

What you'll demonstrate

- Map the team's current capabilities against what Northstar needs
- Design individual development that serves both the person and the business
- Introduce a lightweight progression framework where none exists
- Turn a group of individuals into a deliberately structured team

What to submit

- A QA Capability Development Plan for the team
- A completed QA Skills Matrix and Team Capability Heatmap
- An Individual Development Plan for at least Sofia and Dan
- A proposed QA Career Progression Framework tailored to Northstar's size

Step-by-step

1. Populate the QA Skills Matrix across the capabilities Northstar actually needs, including the gaps in performance, security and accessibility
2. Build the Team Capability Heatmap to expose concentration risk and single points of failure
3. Draft the QA Career Progression Framework so testers can see a route forward at a Series B company
4. Write Individual Development Plans for Sofia and Dan that connect their growth to real Northstar work
5. Assemble the capability development plan, sequencing hiring, training and internal growth realistically

Submission format

Submit as a PDF or DOCX including the skills matrix, heatmap, progression framework and individual plans.

How your work is assessed

If a QA lead reviewed this, they would look for:

- Development tied to Northstar's delivery needs, not generic training wish-lists
- Honest treatment of capability gaps and key-person risk
- A progression framework proportionate to a ~55-person engineering org
- Individual plans that would genuinely motivate Sofia and re-engage Dan
- A build-versus-hire view that is realistic about cost discipline

Templates & resources to use

- QA Skills Matrix — find it in the Resource Vault.
- Individual Development Plan — find it in the Resource Vault.
- Team Capability Heatmap — find it in the Resource Vault.
- QA Career Progression Framework — find it in the Resource Vault.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

People stay when they can see where they are going. A simple, visible progression framework will retain more talent at Northstar than any one-off training budget — and it costs almost nothing to introduce.